THE ART OF MAKING AN IMPACT

India has taken considerable strides in the fields of films, performing and fine arts and sports in the past few years. Buoyed by private and state push, Indian talent has been finding recognition globally. While challenges remain, the future is promising

By **Suhani Singh**

BIG SCREEN, BIG COLLECTIONS

International earnings of some of the big Indian grossers of the past decade



**DANGAL* (2016) ▼
$291.33mn



**PK* (2014) ▼
$89.75mn

Pathaan (2023) ▶
$95.1mn



In May 2024, TikTok saw the genesis of a trend that many found bewildering—women and girls from across the world shooting reels while they applied make-up wearing traditional Indian attire and lip-synced to the song "*San Sanana*", from the 2001 Hindi film *Asoka*. That a two-decade-old song could suddenly start trending online with the hashtag "AsokaMakeup" is just one of the many examples of India's cultural sway today. And you certainly cannot underestimate the role of a country's soft power—whether through arts or sports—one that India can well expand.

From Diljit Dosanjh enthralling concertgoers at the Coachella music festival, to Indian fashion designers making waves on the international circuit and artists having their works showcased at renowned museums like the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA), India is becoming more proficient in the art of showcasing its rich and varied culture. But nowhere is it more visible than in the growing presence of Indian films abroad. Last year, the world's most prolific film industry had 339 of its titles release across 38 countries and, in a rare instance, Hollywood Lionsgate studio bought the remake rights of the violent action thriller *Kill* this year. Netflix felt confident splurging nearly Rs 200 crore on Sanjay Leela Bhansali's OTT debut *Heeramandi*—which was four years in the making—and had it dubbed in languages like Arabic, Malay, French, Thai and German. The OTT giant's investment paid dividends, with the show featuring in the top 10 in 43 countries following its release this year.

It wasn't the first time that an Indian title had become part of the global chatter with the help of streaming platforms. In 2020, *Delhi Crime* became the first Indian web series to win an International Emmy award. For Indian films to resonate globally, Somen Mishra, head of creative development and a producer at Karan Johar's Dharma Entertainment, says Indian filmmakers need to follow a simple diktat: "The more local you think, the more global you can go. Give audiences a peek into the world that they have not seen. Not everything crosses over because it needs to be of a certain